were pointed at the SIT and their inability to catch the mastermind, who, showing a clean pair of heels, sneaked out of Tamil Nadu hiding in an oil tanker and landed in neighbouring Karnataka. Sivarasan had, by then, grown bigger than everyone. I visited the residence of retired director general (intelligence) of Tamil Nadu police, Kondath Mohandas. The ace sleuth questioned the ‘intriguing circumstances’ in which Sriperumbudur had been added to Rajiv Gandhi’s itinerary despite objections from several quarters. He pointed out an earlier report where Yasser Arafat, chairman of the Palestine Liberation Organization, had warned India about a possible threat from the Mossad, Israel’s national intelligence agency. Mohandas emphatically claimed that the LTTE was being used as a front by vested interests operating not just from Jaffna.

Meanwhile, I could see a clear divide within the SIT. While one section felt the investigation did not need to not look beyond the LTTE, a few others felt overlooking the foreign links of Sivarasan would not only be a disservice to their profession but also an injustice to Rajiv Gandhi. They dared to do what no other CBI official attempted—bring Rajiv’s true assassins to justice. Ridiculed by the press, denounced by their seniors and harassed by New Delhi, these officers were tormented by those who clung fast to the idea of the LTTE as the only villain in the conspiracy. With their career on the line, at least two officers persisted in the belief that the footprints of the assassins would lead them beyond Jaffna.

This, therefore, is the story of the officers who successfully brought the conspirators to trial but were prevented every step of the way from unearthing the larger conspiracy. This is also the story of the pervasive subterfuge, outright lies and deceptions of the intelligence agencies, the sympathetic stance of some very senior policemen from Tamil Nadu who owed their allegiance to the LTTE, and the mysterious deaths of key witnesses just before their testimonies were due. It was a complex web, where not only was the truth forbidden but also where the necessity to catch the mastermind alive was systematically jeopardized.

Over the years it was my inability to decide what information to keep and what to leave out, if any at all, that stopped me from writing on a